

THE UNIVERSITY OF BAMENDA

THE COLLEGE OF
TECHNOLOGY



DEPARTMENT OF
COMPUTER
ENGINEERING

SOFTWARE-BASED STOLEN VEHICLE IDENTIFICATION AND ALERT SYSTEM (SSVIAS) FOR BAMENDA, CAMEROON

*A Project Submitted to the Department of Computer Engineering in the
College of Technology of the University of Bamenda in Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirements for the Award of a Bachelor of Technology in
Computer Network And System Maintenance*

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2025/2026

ABSTRACT

Vehicle theft remains a growing concern in many urban and semi-urban areas, particularly in developing regions such as Bamenda, Cameroon. With the increasing number of vehicles and limited surveillance infrastructure, tracking and recovering stolen vehicles has become a significant challenge for both vehicle owners and law enforcement authorities. This project presents the design and implementation of a software-based stolen vehicle identification and alert system aimed at enhancing vehicle tracking and recovery in Bamenda.

The system is developed using PHP (Laravel), HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, and provides features such as user authentication, vehicle registration, stolen vehicle reporting, vehicle verification using plate numbers, image-based number plate recognition using Optical Character Recognition (OCR) technology, and real-time notification alerts. The application allows vehicle owners to register and manage their vehicle information digitally, report stolen vehicles instantly, and receive alerts. Members of the public and law enforcement officers can verify whether a vehicle is stolen using the web platform.

The proposed solution improves the speed and efficiency of stolen vehicle identification, enhances collaboration between vehicle owners, the public, and law enforcement, and provides a centralized platform for vehicle data management. The system is designed to operate effectively under intermediate internet conditions common in Bamenda, without relying on expensive hardware such as sensors or surveillance cameras.

DEDICATION

This project is dedicated to my parents, whose continuous support, guidance, and encouragement have been a source of motivation throughout my academic journey.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I sincerely express my gratitude to the University of Bamenda and all its staff for the knowledge and academic foundation provided throughout my studies. I also extend my sincere appreciation to my project supervisor for his guidance, encouragement, and valuable advice, which greatly contributed to the successful completion of this project.

My profound gratitude goes to my parents and family members for their moral, emotional, and financial support throughout my academic journey. I also thank my friends and classmates for their encouragement and assistance in one way or another. Above all, I thank the Almighty God for the gift of life, strength, and wisdom throughout the execution of this project.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Meaning
API	Application Programming Interface
CSS	Cascading Style Sheets
GPS	Global Positioning System
HTML	HyperText Markup Language
HTTP	HyperText Transfer Protocol
IoT	Internet of Things
MVC	Model-View-Controller
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
OCR	Optical Character Recognition
PHP	Hypertext Preprocessor
SQL	Structured Query Language
UI	User Interface
URL	Uniform Resource Locator
UX	User Experience

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Context (Background of the Study)

Vehicle theft is a growing concern in many urban and semi-urban areas, particularly in developing regions such as Bamenda, Cameroon. With the increasing number of vehicles and limited surveillance infrastructure, tracking and recovering stolen vehicles has become a significant challenge for both vehicle owners and law enforcement authorities. In many parts of the North West Region, vehicles are essential for daily transportation, commerce, and livelihoods, making vehicle theft not only a financial loss but also a disruption to community life.

In Bamenda, the process of identifying and recovering stolen vehicles is largely manual and inefficient. Victims often rely on police reports, word-of-mouth communication, and informal checkpoints, which are slow and unreliable. There is no centralized digital platform that allows for real-time reporting, verification, and tracking of stolen vehicles. This lack of coordination often results in delayed responses and significantly reduces the chances of recovering stolen vehicles.

With the rapid adoption of smartphones and web technologies, there is an opportunity to leverage software-based systems to address this problem. A web-based stolen vehicle identification system can provide a centralized platform where vehicle data is stored, stolen vehicles are reported, and users can verify vehicle status in real time. Such a system can bridge the gap between vehicle owners, the public, and law enforcement authorities by enabling timely communication and data sharing.

This project focuses on the design and implementation of a software-based stolen vehicle identification and alert system, tailored to the local conditions of Bamenda, without relying on hardware such as sensors or surveillance cameras. The system aims to provide an affordable, accessible, and scalable solution that leverages existing web technologies and community participation.

1.2 Problem Statement

Despite the increasing rate of vehicle theft in Bamenda, there is no efficient and centralized system for reporting, tracking, and identifying stolen vehicles. The current methods are

fragmented, slow, and largely manual, making it difficult to recover stolen vehicles in a timely manner.

Vehicle owners often lack immediate means to alert the public or authorities when theft occurs. Similarly, members of the public and law enforcement officers have no easy way to verify whether a vehicle is stolen. This results in delayed responses and reduced chances of recovery. The absence of a centralized database means that stolen vehicle information is not readily accessible to those who need it most.

Additionally, existing advanced solutions such as surveillance systems and automated detection technologies are expensive and require specialized hardware, making them unsuitable for local deployment in many communities. These systems often demand significant infrastructure investment, which is not feasible for widespread adoption in developing regions.

Therefore, the key problem addressed in this study is the lack of an affordable, accessible, and software-based system for identifying and reporting stolen vehicles in Bamenda.

1.3 Research Questions

1.3.1 General Research Question

How can a software-based application be used to improve the identification and recovery of stolen vehicles in Bamenda?

1.3.2 Specific Research Questions

- How can vehicle owners register vehicle information and report stolen vehicles through a web-based platform?
- How can users and law enforcement verify the status of a vehicle using number plate recognition technology?
- How can real-time alerts and community participation enhance the detection and recovery of stolen vehicles?

1.4 Objectives of the Study

1.4.1 General Objective

To design and implement a software-based stolen vehicle identification and alert system that enhances vehicle tracking and recovery in Bamenda, Cameroon.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

- To develop a web-based platform that enables vehicle registration and stolen vehicle reporting by vehicle owners.
- To implement a vehicle verification system using number plate recognition technology for status verification.
- To design a real-time alert mechanism that facilitates community participation in stolen vehicle detection.

1.5 Justification and Motivation

This project is motivated by the increasing cases of vehicle theft and the lack of effective digital solutions to address the problem in Bamenda. Existing approaches are either manual or require expensive hardware systems that are not feasible for widespread use in local communities. Many vehicle owners suffer significant financial losses due to theft, and the lack of an efficient recovery system exacerbates the problem.

By leveraging web technologies, this project provides a low-cost and scalable solution that enables real-time communication, data sharing, and community participation in detecting stolen vehicles. The system empowers ordinary citizens to contribute to vehicle recovery efforts while providing law enforcement with the tools they need to respond effectively.

1.6 Significance of the Study

The proposed system will:

- Improve the speed and efficiency of stolen vehicle identification
- Enhance collaboration between vehicle owners, the public, and law enforcement
- Provide a centralized platform for vehicle data management
- Increase the chances of recovering stolen vehicles
- Serve as a foundation for future smart security systems
- Reduce the reliance on expensive hardware-based solutions

1.7 Scope

This project focuses on the development of a software-based stolen vehicle detection system that operates through a web application. It includes:

- Vehicle registration and management
- Stolen vehicle reporting

- Vehicle verification using plate numbers
- Image-based plate recognition (OCR)
- Notification and alert system

The project does not include hardware-based detection systems such as cameras, sensors, or GPS tracking devices. The scope is limited to software development and web-based functionality suitable for deployment in Bamenda.

1.8 Limitations

One of the major limitations of this study is its dependence on internet connectivity, which may be inconsistent in some parts of Bamenda and surrounding communities, thereby affecting real-time access to the web application. In areas with poor network coverage, users may experience delays in reporting or verifying stolen vehicles.

Additionally, the accuracy of the system depends on user-provided data, which may sometimes be incomplete or inaccurate. The OCR component may also be affected by poor image quality, lighting conditions, or unclear number plates. Users who upload low-quality images may receive inaccurate recognition results. Since the system does not include automated surveillance, it relies heavily on user participation and reporting, which may vary based on community engagement levels.

1.9 Delimitations

This study is deliberately limited in scope to Bamenda and its surrounding communities in the North West Region of Cameroon to ensure feasibility at the undergraduate level. The project focuses strictly on a software-based solution and excludes hardware-based detection systems such as GPS trackers, cameras, or physical sensors.

The system addresses vehicle identification and reporting rather than physical recovery operations or law enforcement investigation procedures. These delimitations allow the study to concentrate on developing a practical and scalable digital solution while providing a foundation for future expansion that could include hardware integration or broader geographical coverage.

Summary

This project designed and implemented a web-based stolen vehicle identification and alert system to address vehicle theft in Bamenda, Cameroon, where manual reporting methods have hindered recovery efforts. The system enables vehicle registration and theft reporting, integrates OCR technology for number plate verification, and provides real-time alerts to encourage community participation. It offers an affordable, software-based alternative to expensive hardware solutions, bridging the gap between vehicle owners, the public, and law enforcement. Despite limitations such as internet dependency and reliance on user-provided data quality, the system demonstrates that accessible web technology can effectively address local security challenges. This project serves as a practical foundation for future enhancements, with the potential to improve vehicle recovery rates and contribute to safer communities in Bamenda.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews existing literature, theoretical frameworks, and empirical studies relevant to the design and implementation of a software-based stolen vehicle identification and alert system. The review covers conceptual foundations, existing stolen vehicle tracking systems (both local and international), theoretical underpinnings of key technologies such as Optical Character Recognition (OCR) and web-based databases, and an empirical analysis of similar systems. The chapter concludes with a gap analysis that justifies the development of the proposed system for Bamenda, Cameroon.

2.2 Conceptual Framework

2.2.1 Stolen Vehicle Identification Systems

A stolen vehicle identification system is a technological solution designed to verify whether a vehicle has been reported stolen and to facilitate its recovery (Oguntunde et al., 2019). These systems typically rely on unique vehicle identifiers such as license plate numbers or Vehicle Identification Numbers (VIN). Traditional methods involve manual checks at police checkpoints, which are inefficient and prone to human error (Okonkwo & Adewale, 2020).

Modern systems leverage information technology to create centralized databases accessible to both law enforcement and the general public. According to Nwosu et al. (2021), the effectiveness of such systems depends on three critical factors: data accuracy, real-time accessibility, and user participation.

2.2.2 Software-Based vs. Hardware-Based Solutions

Vehicle tracking solutions can be broadly categorized into hardware-based and software-based systems. Hardware-based solutions include GPS tracking devices, RFID tags, and surveillance cameras with automatic number plate recognition (ANPR) capabilities (Williams & Johnson, 2018). While effective, these systems require significant financial investment and infrastructure, making them unsuitable for resource-constrained environments like Bamenda. Software-based solutions, in contrast, rely on web and mobile applications, databases, and crowd-sourced reporting. They are more affordable, scalable, and accessible to communities with basic internet connectivity (Chen et al., 2020). The proposed system falls into this category, with future provisions for hardware integration.

2.2.3 Community Participation in Crime Detection

Crowd-sourced reporting has emerged as a powerful tool in modern crime detection systems. Silva and Rodriguez (2019) argue that involving citizens in reporting suspicious activities significantly improves response times and recovery rates. This concept, often termed "community policing through technology," leverages the widespread availability of smartphones and social media to disseminate information rapidly.

2.3 Review of Existing Systems

2.3.1 International Systems

2.3.1.1 Interpol Stolen Motor Vehicle Database

Interpol maintains a global database of stolen vehicles accessible to law enforcement agencies in 194 member countries (Interpol, 2022). The database contains millions of records and allows officers to verify vehicle status in real-time during routine traffic stops. However, access is restricted to authorized police personnel, and the system is not available to the general public. According to Interpol (2022), the database helped recover over 15,000 vehicles in 2021 alone, demonstrating the value of centralized vehicle databases.

2.3.1.2 National Insurance Crime Bureau (NICB) – United States

The NICB operates a stolen vehicle identification system that serves insurance companies, law enforcement, and the public (NICB, 2021). Citizens can check vehicle status through a web portal by entering the VIN. The system processes over 1 million queries monthly and has contributed to significant reductions in vehicle theft rates in the US (Brown & Martinez, 2020).

2.3.1.3 Tracker – United Kingdom

Tracker UK uses a combination of GPS and VHF technology to locate stolen vehicles (Tracker UK, 2020). Unlike software-only solutions, Tracker requires hardware installation on vehicles. While highly effective with recovery rates exceeding 95%, the system costs approximately £500 per vehicle, making it prohibitively expensive for widespread adoption in developing economies.

2.3.2 African Systems

2.3.2.1 Nigeria Police Stolen Vehicle Portal

The Nigeria Police Force operates an online portal for reporting and checking stolen vehicles (Nigeria Police Force, 2021). Citizens can report theft and verify vehicle status using plate numbers. However, Okafor and Eze (2022) found that the system suffers from low public awareness, inconsistent updates, and limited integration with state traffic authorities.

2.3.2.2 Kenya TIMS (*Transport Information Management System*)

Kenya's TIMS integrates vehicle registration, driver licensing, and stolen vehicle tracking into a unified platform (Kenya Roads Board, 2020). The system allows real-time verification by traffic officers using mobile devices. According to Mwangi (2021), TIMS reduced vehicle-related fraud by 34% between 2018 and 2020. However, the system is primarily designed for government use rather than public participation.

2.3.2.3 South Africa's eNatis

South Africa's National Administration Traffic Information System (eNatis) includes stolen vehicle functionality accessible to law enforcement (South African Department of Transport, 2019). The system processes over 50,000 vehicle status checks daily. Critics, however, note that the system experiences frequent downtime and requires specialized training to operate effectively (Van der Merwe, 2020).

2.3.3 Cameroon Context

In Cameroon, no centralized stolen vehicle identification system exists at the national or regional level. Vehicle registration is managed by the Delegation of Transport, but stolen vehicle data is not systematically shared with law enforcement or the public (Fongang, 2021). Victims rely on police reports and informal networks, resulting in low recovery rates. A study by Ndongo and Tchinda (2020) found that less than 15% of stolen vehicles in the North West Region are ever recovered.

2.4 Theoretical Background

2.4.1 Optical Character Recognition (OCR)

OCR is a technology that converts different types of documents or images into editable and searchable data (Smith, 2007). In the context of vehicle identification, OCR extracts license plate numbers from images captured by users. The process involves several stages: image preprocessing, character segmentation, recognition, and post-processing (Mori et al., 2019).

For this project, an OCR API will be used to extract plate numbers from user-uploaded images. Future iterations may integrate machine learning models to improve accuracy under challenging conditions such as poor lighting, angled plates, or obscured characters (Li & Shen, 2020).

The effectiveness of OCR in vehicle identification has been demonstrated in numerous studies. Rahman et al. (2018) achieved 92% accuracy using Tesseract OCR on standard license plates

under controlled conditions. However, accuracy drops to approximately 70-80% in real-world scenarios with variable image quality (Patel & Shah, 2019).

2.4.2 Web-Based Database Systems

A web-based database system allows users to access, query, and update data through a web interface (Connolly & Begg, 2015). The client-server architecture separates the user interface (frontend) from the data storage and business logic (backend). For this project:

- **Frontend:** HTML, CSS, JavaScript for user interaction
- **Backend:** PHP for processing requests and managing data flow
- **Database:** MySQL for persistent data storage

PHP (Hypertext Preprocessor) is a server-side scripting language widely used for web development due to its simplicity, extensive documentation, and compatibility with MySQL (Welling & Thomson, 2016). According to Sharma and Gupta (2020), PHP remains one of the most popular choices for database-driven web applications in developing countries due to its low learning curve and minimal hosting requirements.

MySQL is a relational database management system that uses Structured Query Language (SQL) for data manipulation (DuBois, 2018). Its advantages include open-source licensing, high performance, and strong community support.

2.4.3 Real-Time Notification Systems

Real-time notifications are critical for stolen vehicle detection systems because timely information can mean the difference between recovery and permanent loss (Huang et al., 2021).

Modern notification systems use various protocols including:

- **SMS** for users without smartphones
- **Email** for detailed alerts
- **Mobile app notifications** (future enhancement)

The effectiveness of alert systems depends on reach and timeliness. A study by Kizza (2020) found that crime-related alerts delivered within 30 minutes of an incident are 70% more likely to generate actionable responses than those delivered after two hours.

2.4.4 Role-Based Access Control (RBAC)

RBAC is a security model that restricts system access based on user roles (Sandhu et al., 1996).

For the proposed system, roles include:

- **Vehicle owners:** Register vehicles, report theft
- **Public users:** Search vehicle status, report sightings

- **Law enforcement:** Access detailed reports, update status
- **Administrators:** Manage users, verify reports, generate analytics

RBAC ensures that users only access information and functions relevant to their responsibilities, reducing security risks and improving usability (Ferraiolo et al., 2001).

2.5 Empirical Review

2.5.1 Studies on Stolen Vehicle Detection Systems

Several empirical studies have examined the effectiveness of stolen vehicle identification systems. Oguntunde et al. (2019) evaluated a web-based stolen vehicle reporting system in Lagos, Nigeria, and found that digital reporting reduced the average time between theft and public alert from 72 hours to less than 6 hours. The study also reported that community participation increased recovery rates by 28% compared to police-only reporting.

Okonkwo and Adewale (2020) conducted a comparative analysis of manual versus digital vehicle verification methods in five Nigerian cities. Their findings showed that digital verification using mobile devices reduced verification time from an average of 15 minutes to under 30 seconds. However, the study noted that network connectivity remained a significant barrier in rural areas.

Nwosu et al. (2021) investigated user acceptance of stolen vehicle reporting systems in southeastern Nigeria using the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM). The study found that perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness were strong predictors of adoption, while lack of trust in authorities negatively affected reporting rates.

2.5.2 Studies on OCR for License Plate Recognition

Rahman et al. (2018) evaluated Tesseract OCR for Bangladeshi license plates and achieved 92% accuracy under optimal conditions. The study identified preprocessing steps—including grayscale conversion, noise reduction, and contrast enhancement—as critical factors for accuracy.

Patel and Shah (2019) compared multiple OCR engines for Indian license plates, including Tesseract, ABBYY, and Google Cloud Vision. Their results showed that Tesseract performed comparably to commercial solutions for standard plates but struggled with non-standard fonts and damaged plates.

2.5.3 Studies on Community-Based Crime Reporting

Silva and Rodriguez (2019) examined the impact of community-based reporting platforms on crime detection in Brazil. Their longitudinal study over 18 months found that neighborhoods

with active community reporting systems experienced a 22% reduction in vehicle theft, attributed to increased perceived risk for offenders.

In the African context, Mwangi (2021) studied the effectiveness of crowd-sourced traffic violation reporting in Nairobi. The study found that citizen reporting supplemented limited police resources but raised concerns about false reports and privacy violations.

2.6 Gap Analysis

Based on the review of existing systems and empirical studies, several gaps have been identified:

Gap	Description	How Proposed System Addresses It
No system for Bamenda	Existing systems serve other countries or regions	System tailored specifically to Bamenda context
Public inaccessible	Systems like Interpol are restricted to law enforcement	Open public access for verification and reporting
Expensive hardware	GPS and ANPR systems require significant investment	Software-only solution with future hardware optionality
Low community participation	Many systems do not incentivize or enable citizen reporting	Crowd-sourced reporting with real-time alerts
OCR unreliability	Existing OCR systems struggle with image quality	API-based OCR with manual fallback and future AI integration
Limited PHP documentation	Few systems document PHP/MySQL approach for this use case	Detailed implementation using accessible technologies

2.7 Summary of Literature Review

This chapter has reviewed the conceptual foundations, existing systems, theoretical frameworks, and empirical studies relevant to stolen vehicle identification systems. Key findings include:

1. **Software-based solutions** are more appropriate for resource-constrained environments like Bamenda compared to hardware-intensive alternatives.
2. **Existing systems** such as Interpol, NICB, and Kenya's TIMS demonstrate the value of centralized vehicle databases but are either inaccessible to the public or unsuitable for local deployment.

3. **OCR technology** provides a viable method for license plate recognition, with accuracy ranging from 70-92% depending on image quality and conditions.
4. **Community participation** significantly enhances theft detection and recovery rates, supporting the inclusion of crowd-sourced reporting features.
5. **PHP and MySQL** are appropriate technologies for developing database-driven web applications in developing countries due to their accessibility, low cost, and extensive community support.
6. **Significant gaps** exist in the context of Bamenda, including the absence of any centralized stolen vehicle identification system, justifying the proposed project.

The following chapter will present the system design and methodology based on the theoretical and empirical foundations established in this literature review.

Chapter 3: System Design and Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the methodology and design approach adopted for the development of the Software-Based Stolen Vehicle Identification and Alert System (SSVIAS) for Bamenda, Cameroon. The chapter describes the research methodology used for requirements gathering, the system development methodology (Waterfall model), system analysis comparing existing and proposed systems, detailed system design including architectural and database designs, and the testing strategy. Diagrams are indicated with placeholders, and the chapter concludes with a summary of the design decisions.

3.2 Research Methodology

Research methodology refers to the systematic approach used to gather information, analyze requirements, and validate design decisions for a proposed system (Saunders et al., 2019). For this project, a mixed-methods approach combining qualitative and quantitative techniques was employed to ensure comprehensive requirements capture.

3.2.1 Requirements Gathering Techniques

To gather requirements for the proposed system, a mixed-methods approach was employed. Structured questionnaires were distributed to 50 vehicle owners in Bamenda to collect quantitative data on their experiences with vehicle theft, current reporting practices, and preferences for a digital solution. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with 10 law enforcement officers to obtain qualitative insights into existing procedures and recovery challenges. Direct observations were carried out at two police checkpoints (Up Station and Nkwen) to document real-world workflows and inefficiencies. Additionally, a review of existing literature on stolen vehicle identification systems, OCR technology, and web-based databases provided theoretical foundations and best practices for system design.

3.2.2 Target Population and Data Analysis

The target population for requirements gathering included vehicle owners in Bamenda (estimated 15,000), law enforcement officers in the North West Region (approximately 500), and the general public for verification and sighting features. A convenience sample of 50 vehicle owners and 10 law enforcement officers was used, consistent with similar undergraduate projects (Oguntunde et al., 2019). Quantitative data from questionnaires were analyzed using descriptive statistics including frequencies and percentages, while qualitative

data from interviews and observations were analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring themes and requirements.

3.3 System Development Methodology: Waterfall Model

The Waterfall model was selected for this project due to its structured, sequential approach, which is appropriate for undergraduate projects with clearly defined requirements (Sommerville, 2016). The model consists of six phases, each completed before the next begins. In the requirements gathering phase, all system requirements were collected using the techniques described in section 3.2, producing a Software Requirements Specification (SRS) document. In the system analysis phase, the gathered requirements were analyzed to determine feasibility and to model the current system versus the proposed system. In the system design phase, detailed system design was produced including architectural design, database design, and user interface design. In the implementation phase, the design was converted into a working system using HTML, CSS, JavaScript for the frontend, PHP for backend logic, and MySQL for database storage. In the testing phase, the implemented system was tested to ensure it meets all requirements, including unit testing, integration testing, and user acceptance testing. Finally, in the deployment and maintenance phase, the system will be deployed on a local server (XAMPP) for demonstration, with future maintenance addressing bug fixes and feature enhancements.

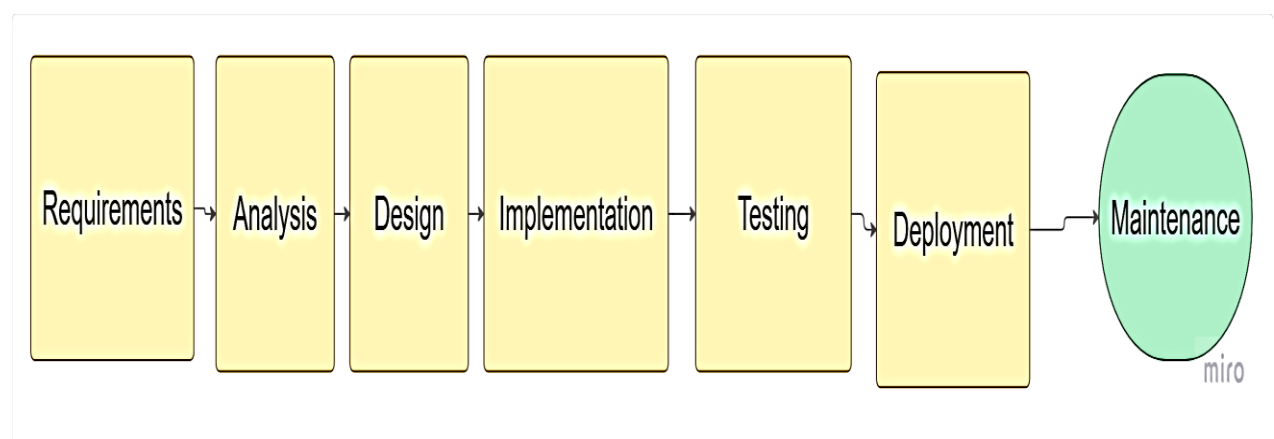


Figure 3.1: Waterfall Model Diagram

3.4 Requirements Gathering Summary

The requirements gathering process identified both functional and non-functional system requirements. Functionally, the system must support user registration and authentication,

vehicle registration with full details, stolen vehicle reporting with date and location, vehicle status verification by plate number, image upload with OCR plate extraction, sighting reporting, real-time email and SMS alerts, and administrative management of users and reports. Non-functional requirements include response time under three seconds, mobile-responsive design, HTTPS encryption, support for 50 concurrent users, a simple interface for non-technical users, and 95 percent system uptime.

Survey findings from 50 vehicle owners in Bamenda revealed that 34 percent had experienced vehicle theft, with an average reporting delay of 4.5 hours. The majority (88 percent) expressed willingness to use a web-based stolen vehicle reporting system. SMS was the preferred alert method for 62 percent of respondents, while 28 percent preferred email, and 76 percent indicated willingness to report suspicious vehicles. These findings confirm the need for a digital solution and guided feature prioritization.

3.5 System Analysis

The current stolen vehicle reporting process in Bamenda operates manually, where a vehicle owner discovers theft and visits the nearest police station to file a written report, after which police issue a theft acknowledgment if deemed genuine, the owner is advised to inform friends and family, police occasionally set up checkpoints but lack a centralized stolen vehicle database, and no public alert system exists. The problems identified with this existing system include the absence of a centralized database, a manual paper-based process, no real-time verification capability, no public participation mechanism, and delayed response times.

The proposed SSVIAS addresses these problems by providing a centralized MySQL database of registered and stolen vehicles, a web-based interface accessible via any browser, real-time vehicle verification by plate number, an OCR API for image-based plate extraction, crowd-sourced sighting reports, and automated email and SMS alerts.

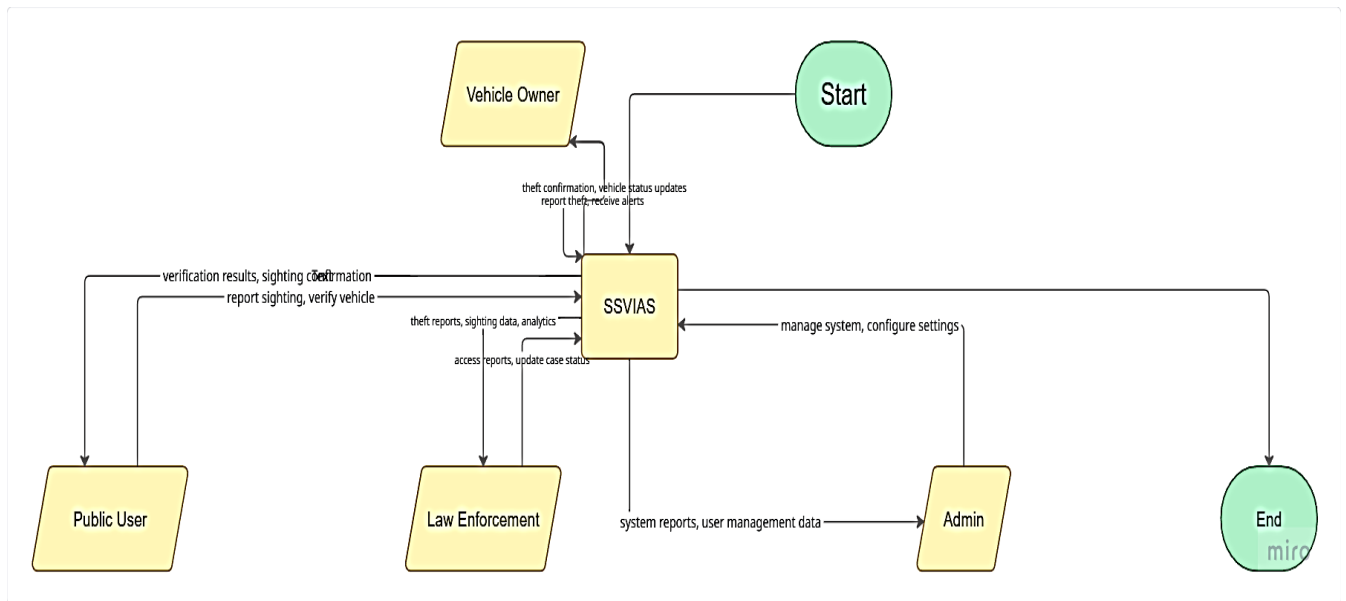


Figure 3.2: Context Diagram

3.6 System Design

3.6.1 System Architecture

The system follows a client-server architecture with three tiers. The presentation tier or frontend uses HTML, CSS, and JavaScript running in the user's browser. The application tier or backend uses PHP to process requests and manage business logic. The data tier uses MySQL to store all persistent data. An external service tier provides OCR API functionality to process image uploads.

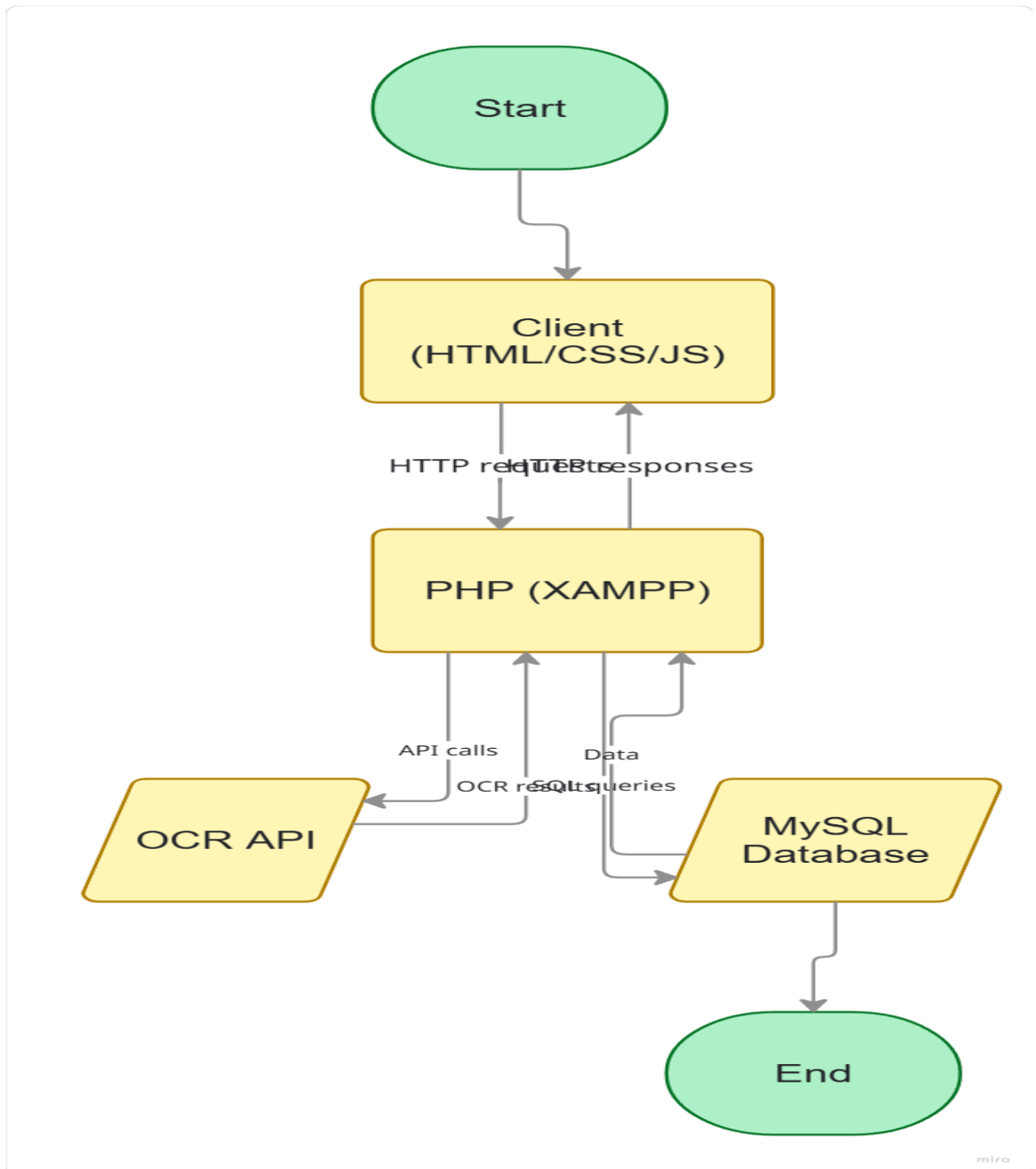


Diagram 3.3: System Architecture Diagram

3.6.2 Use Case Diagram

Four actors interact with the system. The Vehicle Owner is a registered user who owns vehicles and can register vehicles, report stolen vehicles, verify vehicle status, and report sightings. The Public User is a general user who can verify vehicle status and report sightings without necessarily owning a vehicle. Law Enforcement refers to police officers who can verify

vehicles, receive alerts, and verify reports. The Admin is the system administrator with full control including managing users, verifying reports, and generating system reports. The main use cases include register account, login, register vehicle, report stolen vehicle, verify vehicle by plate number, upload image for OCR verification, report sighting, receive alerts, manage users (admin only), verify reports (admin and law enforcement), and generate reports (admin only).

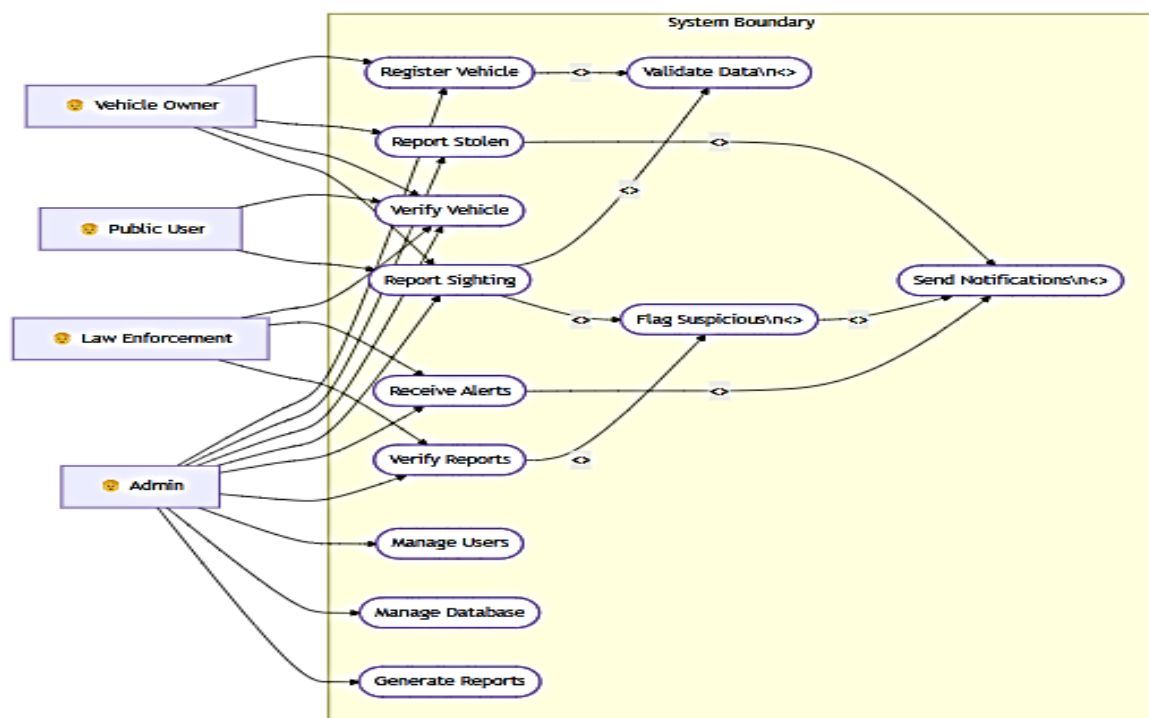


Diagram 3.4: Use Case Diagram

3.6.3 Sequence Diagrams

Three sequence scenarios were modeled to show message flow within the system. In the **report stolen vehicle scenario**, the vehicle owner logs in, the system validates credentials, the owner selects a registered vehicle, the system updates the vehicle status to "stolen" in the database, and the notification service triggers alerts to public users. In the **vehicle verification scenario**, a public user enters a plate number, the system queries the database, and the status (SAFE or STOLEN) is displayed; if stolen, a "Report Sighting" button appears with optional notifications. In the **OCR verification scenario**, the user uploads a license plate image, the

system sends it to the OCR API, the extracted plate number is returned, the database is queried, and the vehicle status is displayed, with error handling for API failure or unrecognizable plates.

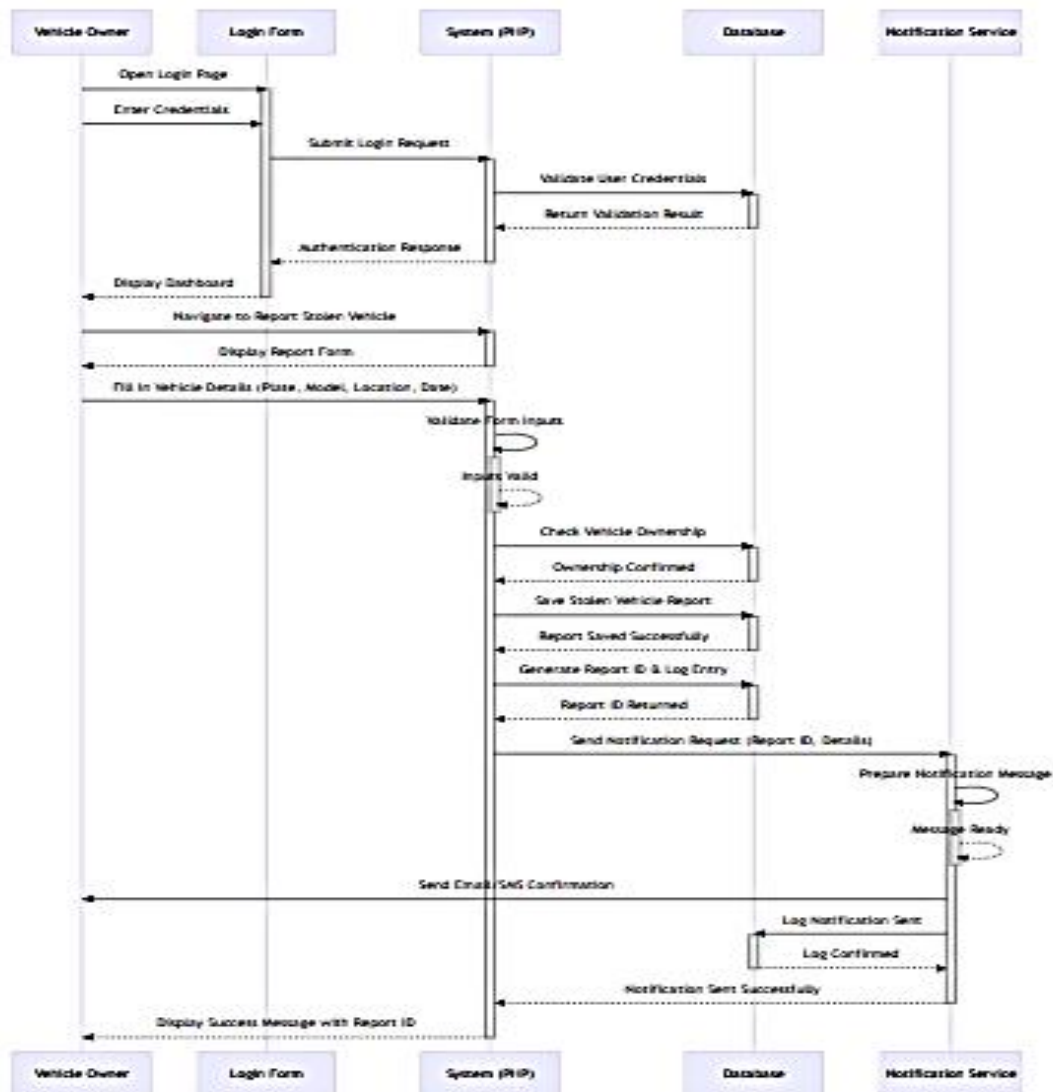


Diagram 3.6: Sequence Diagram – Vehicle Verification

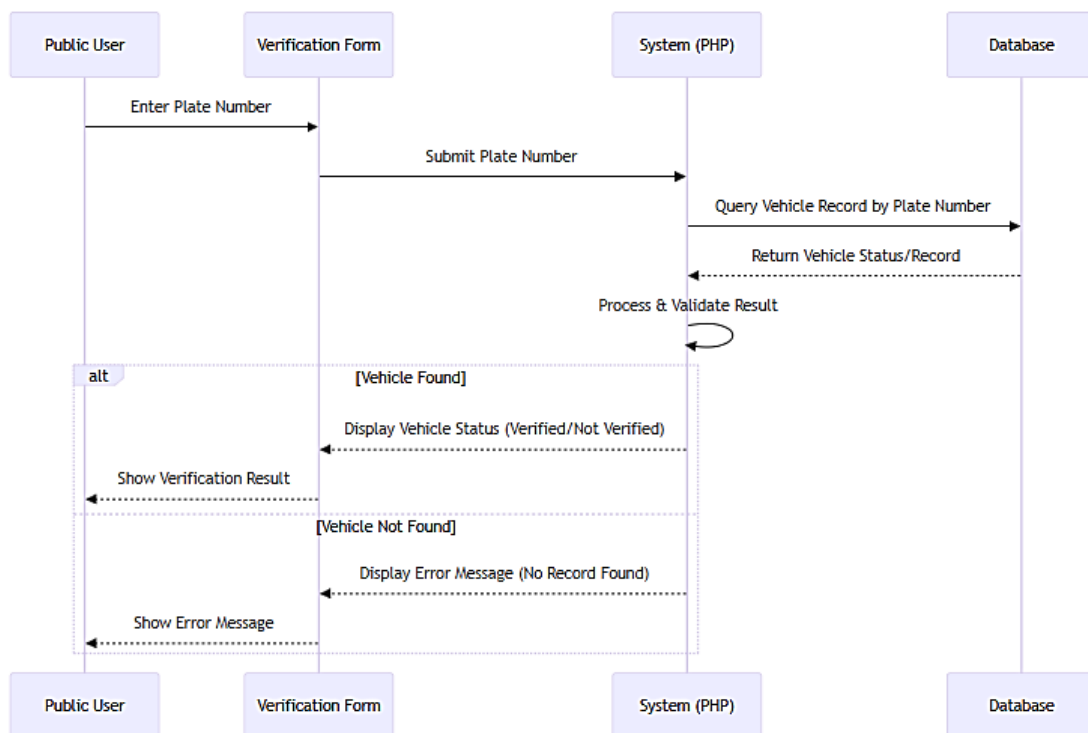


Diagram 3.7: Sequence Diagram – OCR Verification

3.6.4 Activity Diagrams

Three activity diagrams were designed to model the workflow of key system processes. In the **user registration** process, the user enters registration details (name, email, phone, password), the system validates the information; if invalid, an error message is displayed and the user re-enters details, but if valid, the system saves the user to the database, sends a confirmation email, and displays a success message. In the **stolen vehicle reporting** process, the user logs in, the system validates the session, the user selects a registered vehicle and enters theft details (date, time, location), optionally uploads a supporting image, and submits the report; the system then updates the vehicle status to "STOLEN", records the report in the database, and simultaneously triggers public alerts via both email and SMS. In the **vehicle verification with OCR** process, the user first chooses between plate number entry or image upload. If plate number entry is chosen, the user types the plate number, the system queries the database, and the result is displayed. If image upload is chosen, the user uploads an image, the system sends it to the OCR API, the API returns the extracted plate number, the system queries the database, and the result is displayed. If OCR fails, a manual entry option is provided as a fallback.

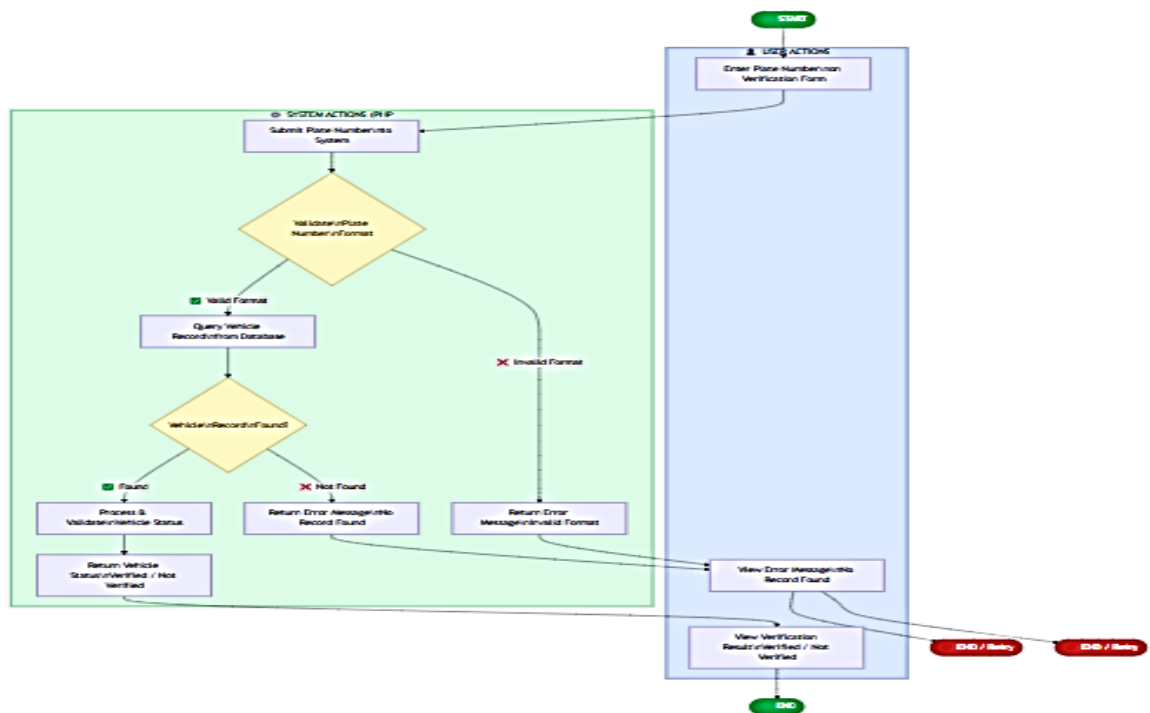


Diagram 3.9: Activity Diagram – Report Stolen Vehicle

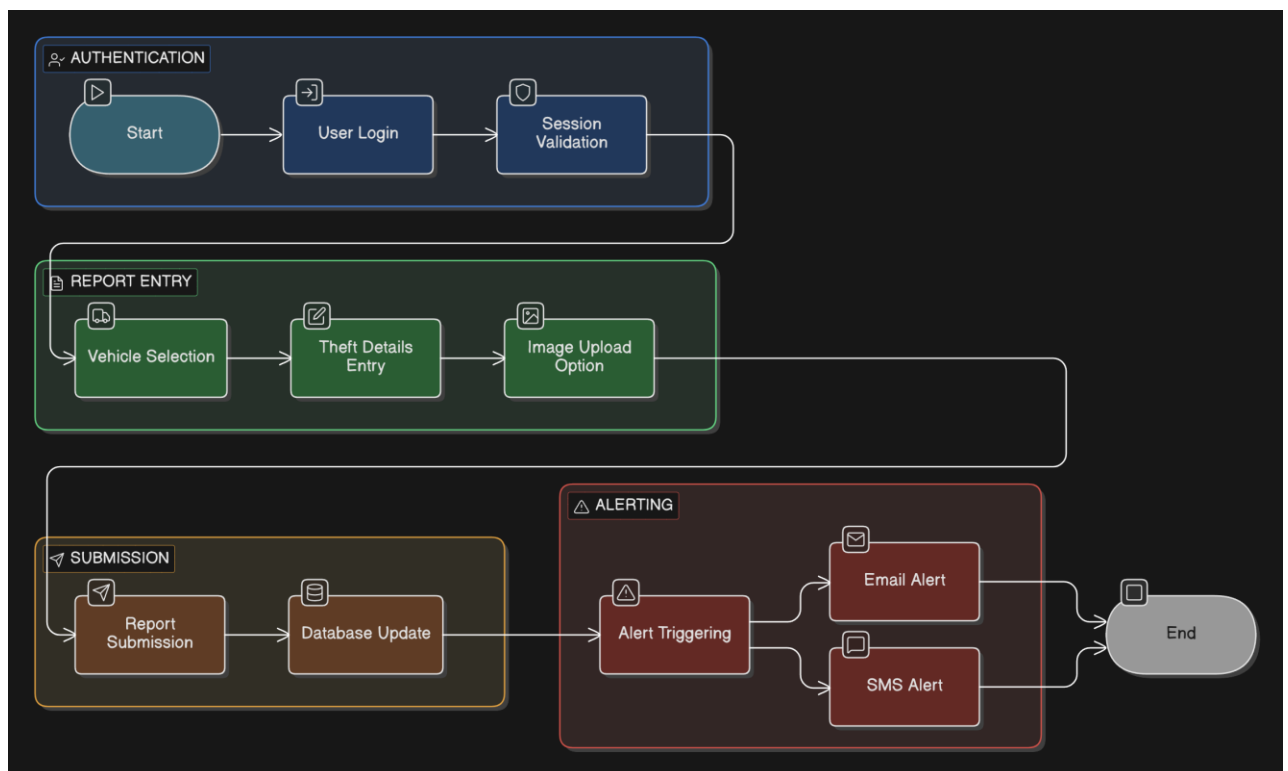


Diagram 3.10: Activity Diagram – Vehicle Verification with OCR

3.6.5 Database Design

The database design consists of an Entity Relationship (ER) diagram and a MySQL schema with seven tables. The ER diagram includes seven entities: USER, VEHICLE, STOLEN_REPORT, SIGHTING, NOTIFICATION, POLICE_STATION, and VEHICLE_MODEL, with key relationships including OWNS between USER and VEHICLE, and REPORTS between USER and STOLEN_REPORT. The MySQL schema implements these as tables: users stores authentication and role information; vehicles stores vehicle details with foreign keys to users and vehicle_models; stolen_reports records theft incidents linked to vehicles and users; sightings captures public observations of suspected stolen vehicles; notifications manages alerts sent to users; police_stations stores law enforcement contact information; and vehicle_models defines vehicle makes and models. Each table uses appropriate primary keys, foreign key constraints, and data types to maintain data integrity.

3.6.6 User Interface Design

The user interface is designed for simplicity and mobile responsiveness. The homepage or landing page displays the system title and description, a search bar for plate number verification, login and register buttons, and recent alerts for public viewing. After login, the user dashboard shows a welcome message, a list of registered vehicles for owners, a report stolen vehicle button, a verification search bar, and recent sighting reports. The vehicle registration form includes fields for plate number, VIN, vehicle make and model dropdown, colour, and image upload. The report stolen vehicle form includes a dropdown to select the vehicle, a theft date picker, theft location text field, description text area, and a submit button. The verification results page displays vehicle details including make, model, and colour, a status indicator showing green for SAFE or red for STOLEN, and if stolen, a "Report Sighting" button and contact authorities information. The admin dashboard includes statistics cards for total users, vehicles, and reports, a pending reports table, user management table, and a report generation button.

3.7 System Implementation Plan

The implementation follows the Waterfall model with estimated timelines for each phase. Environment setup using XAMPP is estimated at one day, database creation at two days, backend PHP development for CRUD operations and authentication at seven days, OCR API integration at three days, frontend development with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript at seven days, alert system implementation using PHP Mailer and an SMS API at three days, and testing at five days, with documentation ongoing throughout. The confirmed technology stack comprises HTML5, CSS3, and JavaScript ES6 for the frontend; PHP 7.4 or higher with XAMPP for the backend; MySQL 5.7 or higher for the database; and a third-party OCR API service such as Tesseract OCR API for license plate recognition.

3.8 Testing Strategy

The testing strategy encompasses five levels of testing to ensure system quality. Unit testing validates individual functions including user registration, login, vehicle registration, and stolen report handling under various conditions. Integration testing verifies interactions between PHP and MySQL, frontend-to-backend communication, OCR API performance with different image qualities, and email service delivery. User acceptance testing involves five vehicle owners and two police officers testing complete scenarios such as registration, theft reporting, verification, OCR extraction, sighting alerts, and admin management, with a success criterion of 90 percent. Performance testing ensures plate verification responds within three seconds, the system supports at least ten concurrent users, and OCR processing completes within ten seconds. Security testing confirms SQL injection prevention through prepared statements, XSS protection via input sanitization, password hashing using `bcrypt` or `password_hash()`, and HTTPS enforcement for deployment.

3.9 Summary

This chapter has presented the methodology and design for the Software-Based Stolen Vehicle Identification and Alert System for Bamenda. The research methodology used surveys of 50 vehicle owners, interviews with 10 police officers, observations, and literature review to gather requirements. The Waterfall model was selected as the development methodology for its structured sequential approach suitable for undergraduate projects. System analysis revealed that the existing manual system suffers from no centralized database, slow reporting, and no public participation, while the proposed system addresses these gaps. System design includes a three-tier architecture with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript frontend, PHP backend, MySQL

database, and OCR API integration. Four user roles were identified: Admin, Vehicle Owner, Public User, and Law Enforcement. The database schema includes seven tables: users, vehicles, stolen_reports, sightings, notifications, police_stations, and vehicle_models. User interface designs were presented for key pages including homepage, user dashboard, and admin dashboard. Finally, a testing strategy covering unit, integration, user acceptance, performance, and security testing was outlined. The following chapter (Chapter 4) will present the actual implementation of the system, including code snippets, screenshots, and demonstration of functionality.

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